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An unlikely thread

Bride's social media search for her mom's dress reunites family with lost wedding heirloom

By Allison Kiehl | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

When she was in fifth grade, Lexie Ippolito watched her mother get married in a stunning Michelangelo-style strapless wedding dress. Ippolito, now 28, always imagined that she, too, would one day wear that same beaded gown and matching sheer veil. Once she got engaged, she wanted her mother's to be the first wedding dress she tried on.

But that childhood dream is more elusive than the 2027 bride once thought. This summer, when she and her mom unboxed the preserved gown the family had stored for more than a decade, they instead found a stranger's dress.

"It was just heart-wrenching," Ippolito said, recalling the moment when she opened the preserved gown at her mom's Schaumburg home. "I feel like both our hearts sank to the bottom of our stomachs."

Ippolito set out on a mission to find her mom's missing dress. Embracing the power and connectivity of social media, she hoped her message would reach whoever had her mom's dress and be able to swap the dresses in time for her rehearsal dinner next year. Her posts across TikTok earned thousands of comments and likes, and a recent post to a Facebook page for Chicago-area brides earned almost 2,000 likes and was shared by dozens of brides-to-be offering to help.

Turns out, a partial answer was stitched in the dress. On Friday, Ippolito took a closer look at the stranger's dress and

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At top: Bride-to-be Lexie Ippolito looks over a stranger's wedding dress at her parents' house on Friday in Schaumburg. The stranger's dress had been stored in the family's house for more than a decade. **ANTONIO PEREZ/ CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Above: Lexie Ippolito wanted to wear this dress, her mother's 2009 wedding dress, during celebrations for her wedding in 2027. Renee and Mario Ippolito were married in Portage Park on April 18, 2009. **LEXIE IPPOLITO**

Unusual filing in FBI case draws ire

Judge scolds DOJ, dismisses complaint against 2 ex-agents

By Eric Tucker, Michael Kunzelman and Alanna Durkin Richer
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — A federal judge on Tuesday scolded the Justice Department for its unorthodox handling of a criminal case against two former FBI officials accused of making false statements to Congress about their knowledge of a laptop the Justice Department says belonged to Hunter Biden, the son of former President Joe Biden.

U.S. Magistrate Zia Faruqui struck from the record an amended criminal complaint filed in the middle of the night by the Justice Department that added a new obstruction charge against the two former officials, Nikki Floris and Bradley Benavides. Such charging documents require sign-off from a judge that probable cause exists that a crime was committed by a defendant, and this complaint lacked that.

"It is not our court's practice — and I think it is appropriately not our practice — that unsigned complaints are filed on the docket," Faruqui said.

He later added: "I want to know why the United States is reticent or averse to putting before a probable cause determination that you must believe is righteous. Why today on this one case have you changed the entire history of how you charge cases?"

The dismissal of the superseding complaint was an embarrassing setback for a Justice Department that has undertaken a series of splashy and politically charged investigative actions in the run-up to next week's midterm elections. But the original false statements case against the former officials, announced Friday, remained intact at least for now as Faruqui proceeded Tuesday with a preliminary hearing.

The case accuses the former offi-

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ELECTION 2026
7TH CONGRESSIONAL DISTRICT

Progressive poised to take torch from Davis

Ford looks to sail through his matchup with GOP's Koppie

By Olivia Olander
CHICAGO TRIBUNE



La Shawn Ford, Democratic nominee for the 7th Congressional District, greets volunteer Maria Bailey at a "Rock the Vote" event in Chicago's Austin neighborhood on Oct. 11. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/TRIBUNE**

The congressional district covering downtown Chicago and much of the West Side is set to change hands for the first time in 30 years, and Democratic state Rep. La Shawn Ford looks to sail through his general election matchup and take the torch from retiring U.S. Rep. Danny Davis.

Ford, a longtime resident of the Austin neighborhood, calls himself a "progressive by survival." In the Nov. 3 election in the racially and economically diverse, heavily Democratic 7th Congressional District, he faces Republican Chad Koppie, an 88-year-old frequent candidate who does not live in the district.

"By nature and by life, I'm a progressive," Ford said. "I've had to fight for progressive ideas, and acceptance and change, for the existence of Black people and the unrepresented and unheard populations my whole life, even before I was elected."

Koppie, who has made opposing abortion the center of his campaigns since the 1990s, has called hosting campaign events "futile" and has raised little money. The two candidates have not appeared together in a debate

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ELECTION 2026

'We knew this was going to happen'

What does an elected school board mean for Chicago? More mudslinging, experts say

By Kate Armanini
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicago's push for a fully elected school board promised more community voice. Days out from the historic vote, the race also has become a new venue for the city's infamously rough-and-tumble politics. And candidates are throwing punches.

"If you come to the swamp, you get muddy," said Jonathan Collins, an assistant professor of political science and education at the Teachers College at Columbia University.

Take the AI-generated video school board president candidate Victor Henderson posted on Facebook last week, accusing his opponents of carrying water for their funders. Hilario Dominguez, a former Chicago Teachers Union organizer, holds a rusted bucket labeled "CTU" while Jessica Biggs, a former principal and current board member, carries one labeled "billionaires."

Henderson's bucket, shiny and new, reads "the CPS students." Some commenters were skeptical. "AI? Really?" one wrote.

For almost 30 years, the Chicago Board of Education was a seven-member body handpicked by the mayor. After a decades-long movement, fueled by growing calls for representation, it began a two-year shift to a fully elected,

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Israelis vote as divisive issues swirl

Exit polls indicate voters gave Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's opponents a solid majority in the next parliament. **Nation & World, Page B4**

'I'm moving forward'

Defensive end Montez Sweat returns to the Bears after having to miss two games for a failed drug test. He apologized to teammates and fans. **Sports**



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